

‘In the age of the internet, formal language has become obsolete.’ Discuss.

Key terms

- the age of the internet
 - This is not ornamental but it sets the context for discussion: Students need to explain how the age of the internet has (supposedly) rendered formal language obsolete; otherwise, the response would be deemed irrelevant to the question.
- formal language
 - A style of speech or writing usually associated with social settings that have clear expectations for behaviour and/or decorum.
 - Typically has close associations with standard varieties of English
- obsolete
 - Implies that something is no longer in use, usually because it has been replaced by something newer or more trendy

Potential problems

- Students may lapse into a commentary about how language has deteriorated due to the presumed obsolescence of formal language, or list the pros and cons surrounding the use of formal language, rather than discuss the supposed causal relationship between the age of the Internet and relevance of formal language.
- Students may limit examples to texts found on social media platforms and neglect that the internet also offers a plethora of other formal text types such as academic articles, legal documents and the like. This in turn would potentially limit the scope of their arguments.

Stand

- To say that there is little or no use for formal language in today’s age of the Internet is too extreme a view. Despite signs of changing language norms, formal language still has a central role to play in interactions that take place today.

Approach

- A. In addressing the proposition, students are to explain how characteristics pertaining to the age of the Internet has supposedly led to the decline of formal language.
- B. Students are to explain why formal language still remains relevant in the age of the Internet. It would be a bonus if students could draw a causal link between the age of the internet and the enduring relevance of formal language. Otherwise, simply pointing out that there are uses of formal language that do not go out of trend even in today’s Internet age would suffice.

A1: Due to an increasing shift in social norms towards informality, it is indeed plausible that formal language will lose its relevance in the age of the internet. This is in part **due to the rise of highly interactive communicative platforms, where users are inclined towards the use of informal language.**

Ex. This is in part due to **the (perceived) close interpersonal relationships that users typically have with the person they are communicating with online. Over time, informal language,**

traditionally reserved for close personal relationships, is now used in wider social contexts online. Linguists such as Norman Fairclough and Sharon Goodman have broadly referred to this trend as informalisation.

Ex. Moreover, given that **online interactions often happen in real-time**, the use of formal language would hinder a users' ability to **reply with brevity and speed**. As a result, communication would become unnecessarily inefficient.

Eg: On social media platforms such as Twitter, Facebook, and blogs, there is the ample use of slang words and informal sentence constructions. Even politicians, public institutions and professional writers can be found to use such language features to convey their message more efficiently and connect better with their readers.



For instance, American President Donald Trump is known for his use of Twitter as a means of disseminating his political convictions to the masses. His tweets are often written in a highly casual and conversational tone.

Ex. Even in professional emails, we now see the use of informal language features such as emojis and emoticons. This is in part to **make up for the lack of paralinguistic cues (such as intonation, volume, and pitch) that are prevalent in face-to-face interactions**. These emojis play a key role in conveying the user's attitude and tone, thus preventing potential miscommunication from arising.

A2. Given that **the internet has democratised text production**, many of its users tend to be the **young** and they have a pervasive influence on types of texts produced.

Ex. These young users are **typically interested in the creative use of language as a way of carving out their unique identities and a means of conveying their thoughts and opinions**. As such, they tend to be less concerned with adhering to the norms of formal language. Linguist Naomi Baron terms this marked indifference towards the need for consistency in linguistic usages among language users, particularly the young as 'Linguistic Whateverism'.

Ex. Additionally, there are **some who may not be as familiar or skilled at using formal language**, thus further contributing to its decline.

Eg. **This is evidenced by the rise of the meme culture** (websites such as *knowyourmeme* and dedicated reddit threads) and the use of multimodal texts (GIFs)



For instance, we have seen the proliferation of doge memes (amongst many others) in the last five years. The meme typically consists of either single-word or two-word phrases accompanied by a photo of a Shiba Inu dog. The rules of Standard English are deliberately flouted as a creative means of conveying the high intensity of one's emotions towards a particular issue.

B1. However, there are uses of formal language that remain relevant even in the age of the internet such as the use of formal language as a criterion for success.

Ex. In standardised tests, students are expected to **demonstrate their ability to write and understand a range of texts using formal language**, as seen in O-Level English and A-Level General Paper. In other words, formal language is used to **measure academic achievement, which in turn would help guarantee entry to institutions of higher learning.**

B2. The ability to use formal language is still perceived as a mark of credibility and status, thus it remains to be a highly valued skill even today.

Ex. Given that educational institutions typically teach students to use a formal style of writing, its effective use is often taken as **a sign of an educated individual by the rest of society.**

Ex. Moreover, **powerful institutions in society observe decorum and expect propriety in the form of formal language use.** As such, in order to gain acceptance into these contexts, individuals are still expected to express their thoughts and opinions according to established language norms.

Eg. Some schools, such as Harris Academy in London, that have banned the use of slang on campus out of the fear that their students may never be able to use formal language even when a professional context calls for it.

Eg. In various legislative systems, the Speaker of the House is given the authority to censor individuals who use profanity among other types of mud-slinging language.

B3. Formal language helps to facilitate a clearer communication of ideas.

Ex. The use of formal language typically involves **adherence to the rules of grammar, establishing clear structure to the language and consequently clarity in the communication of ideas.**

Eg: Some would argue that the use of word classes such as subordinate conjunctions (e.g. 'because' and 'although') help to express the relationship between ideas, and thus are still needed to facilitate clear communication.